

Glossary

Agricultural Revolution

The name given to the series of advancements in agriculture in Britain between 1600 and 1850.

Alchemy

The ancient study of matter, which aimed to discover the secret of everlasting life.

Astrolabe

A device used by sailors to measure the height of the sun in order to help them figure out their ship's latitude.

Atom

The smallest part of an element that has the characteristics of that element.

Bollywood

The largest part of the Indian film industry, based in Bombay.

Conduction

The process by which heat or electricity passes through a substance.

Conquistador

One of the Spanish conquerors of the Native American civilizations.

Defibrillator

A machine that is used to correct or restart the beat of the human heart.

Electron

A subatomic particle with a negative charge that orbits an atom's nucleus.

Filament

The part of a light bulb that glows when an electric current is passed through it.

Gravity

The force that attracts all objects together. On Earth, it is responsible for making objects fall downward and for giving things weight.

Industrial Revolution

A period of industrial expansion in Britain and the US starting around 1700.

Insulation

Reducing the flow of heat, to keep things cool or hot. Electrical insulation prevents electric current from flowing.

Internal combustion engine

An engine in which fuel is burned (combusted) to create movement.

Internet

The interconnected network of computers that spans the globe.

Latitude

A measurement of how far north or south of the equator a location is. Latitude lines run from east to west.

Longitude

A measurement of how far east or west of the Prime Meridian an object is. The Prime Meridian is an imaginary line that runs from the North Pole, via Greenwich, England, to the South Pole. Longitude lines run from north to south.

Microbe

A living thing that can only be seen through a microscope. Bacteria are the most common types of microbes.

Microprocessor

The complicated circuits at the heart of a computer that carry out instructions and calculations, and communicate with other parts of the computer.

Middle Ages

The period in European history between the fall of the Roman Empire in the 5th century and the Renaissance in the 1400s.

Molecule

The smallest amount of a compound, consisting of two or more atoms bonded together.

Morse code

A special kind of code that uses dots and dashes to represent letters, useful for long-distance communication.

Neutron

A subatomic particle with no electric charge found in an atom's nucleus.

Nuclear fission

A process in which a nucleus is split by firing neutrons at it to release energy.

Ozone layer

A layer in Earth's atmosphere with a high concentration of ozone, which absorbs harmful radiation from the Sun.

Patent

A government document that grants someone the sole right to make, use, or sell an invention.

Piston

A round metal part that fits tightly in a cylinder. Car engines usually have four or eight pistons, one in each cylinder.

Proton

A subatomic particle with a positive charge found in an atom's nucleus.

Radio wave

A type of energy that is invisible, travels in waves, and can be used to send information, especially sound.

Sextant

A tool that measures the angle between the horizon and objects in the sky, useful for figuring out latitude.

Soviet Union

The Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, a nation that existed from 1922 to 1991 and included modern-day Russia.

Transistor

A tiny electronic component that is used to switch or amplify electric signals.

World Wide Web

The part of the Internet that contains websites, which are navigated by a web browser and are made up of documents that are linked together.